of the four pillars of democracy in India, the judiciary does the best job in upholding democratic norms, followed by the media at 20.3 per cent. While the legislature got only 13.4 per cent—probably a reflection of a dysfunctional Parliament—sadly, the executive has the confidence of only 10.4 per cent. Clearly, the courts are the surest bastion of citizens' rights—or sentiments. There is also a growing belief that the judiciary must counterbalance government excesses, with 56 per cent of respondents saying so, a two percentage point increase since August 2021. There is also a drop from 32 per cent to 29 per cent in the same period in the perception that the judiciary

A THIRD OF RESPONDENTS BELIEVE THE JUDICIARY DOES THE BEST JOB IN UPHOLDING DEMOCRATIC NORMS

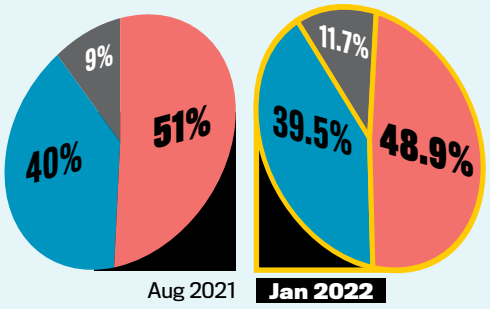
is unnecessarily interfering in matters relating to governance. These are arguably urgent signals of growing public disquiet at the darkening shadows of elected authoritarianism and the need to build robust institutions for citizens' participation in democratic governance.

Both the right to dissent and protest in public as well as the enforcement of law, in cases of financial impropriety, are issues of concern. Our governments have notoriously relied on sedition laws of colonial provenance to silence voices of dissent. A little less than half of those polled (48.9 per cent) believe people are scared to protest or express themselves on any public platform for fear of arrest. That said, respondents holding such apprehensions accounted for 51 per cent of opinion in August 2021, suggesting a marginal decrease in this perception.

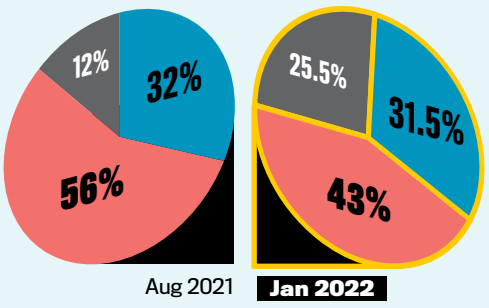
When it comes to fighting that perennial bugbear, corruption, however, the majority of respondents (55.5 per cent) seem convinced that the Narendra Modi government has been effective in reducing it. Over 41 per cent believe that government agencies such as the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation), the ED (Enforcement Directorate), the IT (Income Tax) department and the Central Vigilance Commission, through their searches and inquiries, are better equipped to control corruption. Others (19.9 per cent) believe the courts are the best check, while 13.5 per cent bank on the Lok Pal to do the job.

Privacy is an overwhelming concern (56.4 per cent) for those using digital media such as Facebook, Twitter and WhatsApp; 35.7 per cent of respondents expressed worry and despair over this issue. Another 20.7 per cent are concerned about privacy, but are actively taking action to protect themselves. Many experts point to the recent original traceability laws as a particular threat to the data security and online privacy of Indian citizens .

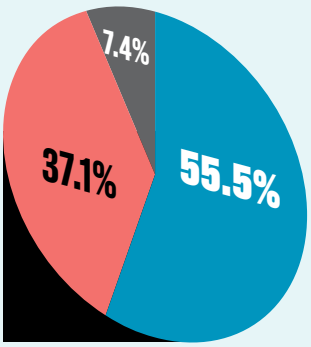
Q. WHAT IS YOUR OPINION ABOUT THE 'RIGHT TO PROTEST' IN PUBLIC IN INDIA?



Q. DO YOU THINK BJP GOVTS. MISUSE ENFORCEMENT AGENCIES (ED/ CBI/ IT DEPT) MORE THAN OTHER GOVTS.?



Q. HAS THE MODI GOVERNMENT SUCCEEDED IN REDUCING CORRUPTION IN INDIA?



(Note: DK/ CS: Don't know, can't say;